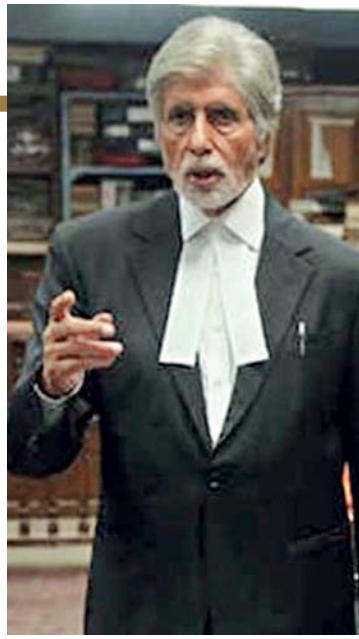


By TAAPSEE PANNU

'Hey, Rockstar!'



I grew up in a family that wasn't obsessed with movies. But we knew that Amitabh Bachchan is a name that's synonymous with Hindi cinema. I was only one Hindi film old when ***Pink*** (2016, right) came my way. More than celebrating being a part of it, I was scared, and couldn't stop thinking, "*Mujhe nikaal denge picture se* [I will be kicked out of the movie]."

We had a reading session at his office in Jalsa. I remember I was, strangely, very calm then. When Mr Bachchan asked what we would like to have, everyone, being so in awe of him, hardly said anything. But I asked him, "What all can you serve?" Everyone looked at me speechless. I asked for green tea. Perhaps this was my way of breaking the ice, ensuring that I am not awkward in his presence. This is not to say I wasn't nervous.

It showed on the first day of the shoot. For one of the scenes, I just had to lie down and sleep, but that shot ended up requiring several takes. My eyelids were constantly fluttering. Thankfully, that was the only shot I gave that day. It was then I realised that it was important that I stop thinking of him as 'the' Amitabh Bachchan. I had great respect for him but I did not want to put him on a pedestal because then, I wouldn't be able to perform and interact and learn from him. I have noticed that when people do this, Mr Bachchan becomes inaccessible, he ends up feeling that he can't have a conversation with the person.

Most of Mr Bachchan's younger co-stars will agree that he is not inflexible about his style. He is still like water, ready to take the shape of the vessel he is in. After a certain point, when one has perfected their craft, they are seldom open to tampering with it. But Mr Bachchan is forever experimenting. When directors ask him for retakes, he agrees. He has his questions but I don't think he has ever shown reluctance in giving another take—or, for that matter, even a director having any hesitation in asking for one.

"Mr Bachchan is forever experimenting with his craft. He is still like water, ready to take the shape of the vessel he is in"

Mr Bachchan prepares extensively for his roles. He can put anyone



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THE BIG LEAGUE
Amitabh with Toby Maguire and Leonardo DiCaprio in *The Great Gatsby*, his Hollywood debut